

STUDY GUIDE

TOPIC: ALL PARTIES CONFERENCE (APC)

THE ASSASSINATION OF BENAZIR BHUTTO 27 DECEMBER 2007
(Bilingual committee)

JT MUN

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Note from the Dais

Esteemed Diplomats,

It is our pleasure to welcome you to the All Parties Conference. As your Dais, we look forward to witnessing thoughtful discourse, meaningful deliberation, and constructive engagement throughout the committee.

This study guide has been prepared to provide you with a foundation for understanding the agenda and initiating your research. However, we strongly encourage you to look beyond the material provided, conduct thorough independent research, and arrive prepared with well-substantiated arguments and informed perspectives.

An effective All Parties Conference requires more than simply presenting individual positions. We encourage all representatives to engage critically with differing viewpoints, defend their positions with evidence, and seek meaningful avenues for consensus where possible.

We expect every delegate to approach the committee with confidence, diplomacy, professionalism, and respect for the diversity of political perspectives represented within the room.

We wish you the very best in your preparation and look forward to an engaging, substantive, and intellectually stimulating committee.

Warm regards,
The Dais
All Parties Conference

INTRODUCTION TO THE COMMITTEE:

The All Parties Conference (APC) occupies a distinctive and consequential position in Pakistan's political history. Although not being established as a permanent constitutional institution, the APC has repeatedly emerged at moments when the country's political system has faced questions too significant to be addressed by the government or opposition in isolation.

An APC brings together representatives of Pakistan's major political forces to deliberate upon matters of national importance, constitutional significance, internal security, foreign policy, electoral legitimacy, democratic transition, and political stability. Its importance derives not from a permanent statutory mandate, but from the political authority and representative character of the parties assembled within it.

Throughout Pakistan's history, political actors have repeatedly turned toward all-parties conferences when conventional political mechanisms have been strained by crisis. In this sense, the APC functions as a forum for national political consultation, capable of bringing government and opposition forces to the same negotiating table and attempting to transform political confrontation into political dialogue.

The APC should therefore be understood not merely as a meeting of political parties, but as a mechanism through which competing political forces may attempt to establish a common national position during periods of extraordinary political uncertainty.

Note: the committee will be set in 2007

OUTLINE OF CRISIS

The crisis will start on *27 December 2007*, straight after the assassination of Benazir Bhutto, at Liaquat Bagh, Rawalpindi. At this time, delegates will be given the roles of political leaders or representatives of the major parties and institutions of Pakistan. It is expected that the crisis will focus on responding to the assassination, and restoring law and order and preventing further political violence, determining how the general elections should proceed, protecting other political leaders, securing and investigating the crime scene, addressing the competing claims over responsibility, maintaining political stability, and deciding how Pakistan should continue its democratic and electoral process.

Delegates should debate these issues from the information and circumstances given at the beginning of the crisis, while developing political, security and investigative responses to the rapidly developing situation.

1.1 MAJOR STAKEHOLDERS

1.1 Government of Pakistan

The Government of Pakistan was one of the key stakeholders since it has the responsibility of maintaining national security and restoring law and order and protecting political leaders, as well as a major constitutional and electoral responsibility to ensure the continuity of the constitutional and electoral process following the assassination. Under President Pervez Musharraf, the government faced questions on why such a major political assassination had taken place despite the known threats against her, as well as a major violence following Bhutto's death and an important decision to make regarding the upcoming general elections. In such circumstances, the Government of Pakistan thus had an interest in stabilizing the country, avoiding further violence, maintaining the state's authority and managing the political crisis while facing accusation and criticism from the opposition.

1.2 Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP)

The Pakistan Peoples Party was directly affected as Benazir Bhutto was its leader and a central political figure. Following her assassination, the PPP had a responsibility to reorganize its leadership, protect its supporters, respond to the widespread mourning and unrest, and also had to determine its position on the election. At the same time, the PPP had an interest in ensuring that the assassination was properly investigated and that those responsible for it would be identified. It would also need to avoid potential anger that could result in further political violence. As such, the PPP's position thus became of major interest to the debates over the investigation, elections and security arrangements and Pakistan's further political future.

1.3 Pakistan Muslim League (N) (PML N)

The Pakistan Muslim League (N) was one of the main civilian political parties and an important stakeholder in the crisis, as it had returned to the national politics after years of political exile and was preparing for the upcoming elections. Following Bhutto's assassination, the party had to respond to the security crisis while deciding on the further course of the political process. It also had an interest in maintaining the civilian political participation and ensuring that the elections would take place under conditions allowing for political parties to campaign safely. Its position was of major importance as it was a key opposition force which could influence the further course of events.

1.4 Pakistan Muslim League (Q) (PML Q)

The Pakistan Muslim League (Q) was associated with the president and one of the major political parties preparing for the 2008 elections. While Bhutto's assassination created a difficult situation for the party as the government it supported was facing accusations over security, political instability and crisis management. Therefore, PML Q had an interest in restoring law and order and maintaining the functioning of the government institutions and continuing the

electoral process. Its representatives would also have to respond to criticism from the opposition concerning the government's responsibility for political security and the protection of Bhutto.

1.5 Muttahida Qaumi Movement (MQM)

The Muttahida Qaumi Movement was an important political force, particularly in urban Sindh and Karachi, and thus had a significant interest in the consequences of Bhutto's assassination. In particular, as Karachi had already experienced serious political violence in 2007, and the city was vulnerable to further unrest. MQM's main concerns included maintaining security, preventing violence between political groups, protecting its supporters and ensuring that economic and commercial activity would continue. As the assassination resulted in serious instability in Sindh, MQM could play an important role in the discussions concerning the public order as well as political cooperation and avoiding further clashes.

1.6 Awami National Party (ANP)

The Awami National Party was a significant civilian political party which operated within Pakistan's political environment at the time. Its presence was particularly strong in the North West Frontier Province – Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, where militant violence and security concerns were already pressing. As such, the assassination impacted the concerns of the party over political violence, terrorism and the safety of political workers. ANP had the interest in maintaining democratic political participation while avoiding the further disruption of political activity by militant organizations. Its position would be relevant to the debates over counterterrorism, election security and protection for political parties.

1.7 Pakistan Army

The Pakistan Army was one of the country's most powerful institutions and a major stakeholder due to its central role in national security during Musharraf's rule. The Army was involved in counterterrorism operations and faced an increasingly serious militant threat in Pakistan. At the same time, its political role was controversial as Musharraf was the President and Army Chief for much of 2007. Following Bhutto's assassination, the Army's concerns included maintaining national stability, supporting internal security operations and preventing the crisis from developing into widespread violence. In addition, political parties and parts of the public questioned the appropriate role of the military in Pakistan's political system, making the Army an important stakeholder in the wider crisis.

1.8 Inter Services Intelligence (ISI)

The Inter Services Intelligence Directorate was an important security stakeholder due to its role in gathering intelligence concerning militant organizations and threats to national security. Before Bhutto's assassination, there had already been warnings concerning threats against her and other political figures. Following the attack, questions arose as to what intelligence was available, whether warnings had been communicated effectively and if the security agencies had

taken appropriate measures to prevent it. As such, the ISI had an interest in identifying militant threats, preventing further attacks and supporting the investigation, while also facing political scrutiny over its role and activities.

1.9 Pakistan Police and Law Enforcement

The police and other civilian law enforcement institutions were responsible for providing much of the initial security for political rallies, protecting political leaders, controlling crowds and investigating crimes. Their role became particularly important following the assassination as widespread violence required large numbers of personnel to restore public order. Questions concerning the security arrangements at Liaquat Bagh, the protection of Bhutto's convoy and the handling of the crime scene also placed law enforcement agencies under scrutiny. Their priorities included preventing further attacks, controlling riots, protecting important locations and preserving evidence for the investigation.

1.10 Election Commission of Pakistan

The Election Commission of Pakistan was responsible for organizing and conducting the upcoming general elections. The assassination presented an enormous challenge to the Commission as election offices and materials were damaged in the violence that followed, while security conditions posed difficulties for the normal election preparations. As such, the Commission had to assess whether elections could take place safely and fairly on the original date of 8 January 2008. Its responsibilities also included protecting electoral materials, rebuilding damaged infrastructure, coordinating with provincial authorities and establishing conditions under which voters and candidates could participate. The question of whether and when the elections should be postponed became the most important institutional issue following the assassination.

1.11 Provincial Governments

The provincial governments were major stakeholders as a significant number of the immediate responses to the assassination were made by provincial police, administration and public-order institutions. The government of Sindh was particularly important as Bhutto had a large political base there and the province experienced some of the most serious unrest following her death. Provincial authorities had to protect government buildings, transport networks, businesses and election infrastructure while preventing further political clashes. They would also have to coordinate with the federal government and security agencies in order to restore stability and ensure that political activity could continue.

1.12 Religious and Political Parties

Pakistan's religious and smaller political parties were also stakeholders as they were participating in or responding to the country's broader political crisis. Different religious or political groups took different positions concerning Musharraf's government, democracy, terrorism, the role of the military and the upcoming elections. Some groups opposed militant

violence and supported political participation, while others took different approaches to Pakistan's political and constitutional system. Their participation was important as the crisis could impact the wider political balance and the ability of different groups to campaign and participate in the electoral process.

1.13 Pakistani Taliban and Other Militant Organizations

Pakistani militant organizations were major security stakeholders as militant violence had become one of the central threats facing Pakistan by late 2007. Different militant groups had different structures, objectives and areas of operation, and responsibility for Bhutto's assassination was disputed at the time. Authorities accused militant elements of involvement, while the investigation considered several possible actors and networks. These organizations thus represented a major security threat for the government and political parties as further attacks could pose a threat to political leaders, election campaigns, polling stations and civilians. Their activities also impacted the debate over counterterrorism and the use of security forces inside Pakistan.

1.14 Pakistani Media

The Pakistani media played an important role in shaping the public opinion surrounding the assassination and the political crisis. Television channels, newspapers and journalists reported on Bhutto's death, the subsequent violence, competing claims concerning responsibility and the government's response. Media organizations also provided a platform for political parties and public officials to express their positions. As such, it was important to the public confidence in the investigation and government response, and thus an important element of the crisis. At the same time, the media organizations operated in a politically sensitive environment following the restrictions imposed during the 2007 emergency.

1.15 Civil Society and Lawyers

Civil society organizations, lawyers and professional groups had already had an important role in Pakistan's political crisis during 2007, particularly through the lawyers' movement concerning the judiciary. Following Bhutto's assassination, civil society faced the situation of having to respond to political violence while demanding constitutional government, accountability and the protection of democratic institutions. Lawyers and civil society organizations could impact the discussions over the rule of law, the investigation and the government's response. Their involvement was particularly relevant as the assassination occurred following months of political conflict over the judiciary and constitutional order.

1.16 The Pakistani Public

The Pakistani public was ultimately one of the most directly affected stakeholders as the assassination and subsequent unrest impacted security, transportation, businesses, elections and everyday life. Bhutto had supporters across the country, particularly in Sindh, while other citizens were concerned primarily with restoring stability and avoiding further violence. The public also had a direct interest in whether elections would take place, whether political leaders

could campaign safely and in whether those responsible for the assassination would be identified. As such, public reaction was an important factor in determining the political pressure placed on the government and political parties following 27 December 2007.

2.0 HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

2.1 The Origins of the Bhutto Political Legacy

Without first examining the political career of Benazir Bhutto's father, history of the Pakistan Peoples Party and the Bhutto family cannot begin. Zulfikar Ali Bhutto founded the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) in 1967 and transformed it into one of Pakistan's most important mass political organizations. The PPP presented itself as a party representing ordinary Pakistanis and gained particularly strong support among workers, lower income groups and large sections of the population in Sindh. Zulfikar Ali Bhutto became President of Pakistan in 1971 and later Prime Minister under the 1973 Constitution. His government introduced major political, economic and foreign policy changes, including the nationalization of several industries and the development of Pakistan's nuclear programme. However, relations between his government, opposition parties and the military became increasingly tense. On 5 July 1977 General Muhammad Zia ul Haq overthrew Bhutto's government in a military coup and imposed military rule. Zulfikar Ali Bhutto was subsequently imprisoned, tried for conspiracy to murder and executed on 4 April 1979. His execution became one of the most controversial events in Pakistan's political history and transformed the Bhutto family into a powerful political symbol. For supporters of the PPP, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto became a symbol of civilian politics and resistance to military rule while his opponents continued to view his government through the lens of allegations of authoritarianism, political violence and poor governance.

2.2 Benazir Bhutto's Rise in the PPP

Following her father's imprisonment and execution Benazir Bhutto gradually became the most important figure within the PPP. She had already been politically active during the period of General Zia ul Haq's military government and experienced periods of detention and house arrest. She eventually went into exile but continued to lead opposition to military rule. After Zia ul Haq's death in a plane crash in August 1988 Pakistan began a transition toward civilian government. The PPP won the largest number of seats in the National Assembly in the November 1988 elections and Benazir Bhutto became Prime Minister in December 1988. At only 35 years old, she became the first woman to lead a government in Pakistan and one of the first women to become head of government in a Muslim majority country. Her election was internationally significant because it demonstrated that a woman could reach the highest political office in a country where political and social structures remained heavily influenced by traditional institutions. However, her government was opposed by the presidency, the military establishment and rival political parties. Her first government was dismissed in August 1990 by President Ghulam Ishaq Khan amid allegations involving corruption, governance and abuse of

authority.

2.3 Benazir Bhutto's Second Government

Benazir Bhutto returned to power after the 1993 elections and became Prime Minister for a second time. Her second government again faced serious political and institutional difficulties. Relations between the PPP government and President Farooq Leghari deteriorated while allegations of corruption and political interference continued to surround the government. In November 1996 President Leghari dismissed Bhutto's government and dissolved the National Assembly. The repeated dismissal of Bhutto's governments contributed to a political environment in which elected governments, presidents, political parties and the military repeatedly struggled over who should exercise effective political authority. By the end of the 1990s, Bhutto remained one of Pakistan's most influential politicians, but her political career was also associated with intense controversy and opposition.

2.4 Benazir Bhutto's Years in Exile

After the dismissal of her second government in 1996 and the PPP's defeat in the 1997 elections Benazir Bhutto spent much of the following years outside Pakistan. She lived primarily in London and Dubai while continuing to lead the PPP and influence its political organization. During this period Pakistan underwent another major political transformation. On 12 October 1999 General Pervez Musharraf overthrew Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif in a military coup and became the country's dominant political figure. Musharraf's takeover meant that Pakistan once again came under military dominated rule. Bhutto remained outside Pakistan while Musharraf consolidated his authority. Her eventual return in 2007 therefore represented not simply the return of an individual politician but the return of one of the country's most important civilian political leaders after years of military rule.

2.5 General Pervez Musharraf's Rule

General Pervez Musharraf became President of Pakistan and remained closely connected to the military establishment. His government introduced a political system in which elected institutions continued to exist, but the military retained substantial influence over national politics and security policy. Musharraf argued that his government was necessary to bring stability and reform to Pakistan, while opposition parties increasingly argued that military influence had to be reduced and civilian democratic institutions strengthened. By 2007 Musharraf's position had become particularly controversial because he was simultaneously President and Chief of Army Staff. This created a major constitutional and political debate over whether a serving military chief should also occupy the country's highest civilian office. Benazir Bhutto's PPP and Nawaz Sharif's PML N were particularly important civilian political forces capable of challenging Musharraf's political position.

2.6 The Judiciary Crisis of 2007

The political crisis became significantly worse in 2007 because of Musharraf's confrontation with the judiciary. On 9 March 2007 Musharraf attempted to remove Chief Justice Iftikhar Muhammad Chaudhry from his position. The Chief Justice refused to resign and challenged the government's action. His case quickly developed into a nationwide political movement led by lawyers and supported by opposition parties, civil society organizations and sections of the media. The Lawyers' Movement became one of the most important challenges to Musharraf's government. On 20 July 2007 the Supreme Court restored Iftikhar Muhammad Chaudhry to his position. The confrontation demonstrated that opposition to Musharraf was expanding beyond traditional political parties and was beginning to involve lawyers, judges, civil society and other sections of Pakistani society.

2.7 The State of Emergency

On 3 November 2007 Musharraf declared a state of emergency and suspended important constitutional protections. He issued a Provisional Constitutional Order requiring judges to take a new oath. Many judges refused to do so and were subsequently removed or placed under restrictions. The government also imposed restrictions on television channels and arrested lawyers, political activists and other opponents. Musharraf justified the emergency by pointing to increasing terrorism, extremism and political instability, while his opponents argued that the measure was primarily intended to weaken the judiciary and protect his political position. The emergency was lifted on 15 December 2007, only twelve days before Bhutto's assassination. Therefore, when Bhutto was killed, Pakistan was still emerging from one of the most serious constitutional crises in its recent history.

2.8 The Growth of Extremism and Militancy

Political instability was accompanied by a rapidly deteriorating security situation. Militant organizations had been active in Pakistan for many years, particularly in the tribal areas bordering Afghanistan but by 2007 extremist violence was increasingly spreading into Pakistan's major cities and targeting government institutions, security personnel and civilians. Suicide bombings became increasingly common. The July 2007 military operation at Lal Masjid in Islamabad became an important turning point. The confrontation between the government and militants at the mosque complex was followed by a major increase in militant attacks across Pakistan. The Pakistani state was consequently facing two major crises simultaneously. It was attempting to manage a political struggle over democracy and constitutional government while also fighting an increasingly violent militant insurgency.

2.9 Pakistan's Relationship

With the War on Terror Pakistan's internal security crisis was closely connected to international politics. After the attacks of 11 September 2001 General Musharraf's government became an important partner of the United States in the international campaign against Al Qaida and other militant organizations. Pakistan received significant international assistance and became an important country in counterterrorism operations. However, cooperation with the United States also made the Pakistani government a target for extremist organizations that viewed the government as an enemy. Benazir Bhutto's political position became particularly sensitive because she supported democratic government and opposed extremist violence while also maintaining relationships with Western governments. To militant organizations, her return therefore represented the possibility that a powerful civilian politician could gain influence over Pakistan's future counterterrorism and security policies.

2.10 Negotiations Between Musharraf and Bhutto

During 2007 negotiations took place between Musharraf and Benazir Bhutto concerning her return to Pakistan and a possible political arrangement. Musharraf faced growing opposition while Bhutto wanted to return to Pakistan and participate in the approaching elections. One of the most important developments was the National Reconciliation Ordinance, issued in October 2007. The NRO provided legal relief in a number of corruption cases involving politicians and officials from previous governments. It affected Bhutto and members of her political circle and became extremely controversial. Supporters viewed the political arrangement as part of a transition toward civilian politics while opponents accused Musharraf and Bhutto of making a political deal for their mutual benefit. Regardless of the political controversy surrounding it, the NRO contributed to the circumstances that allowed Bhutto to return to Pakistan.

2.11 Benazir Bhutto's Return to Pakistan On 18 October 2007

After approximately eight years outside Pakistan Benazir Bhutto returned to Karachi. Her return was an enormous political event. Hundreds of thousands of supporters gathered along the route from Karachi airport to welcome her. The size of the crowd demonstrated that Bhutto continued to possess a large political following and that the PPP remained one of Pakistan's most powerful political organizations. Her return was also directly connected to the upcoming general elections because she intended to campaign for the PPP and potentially return to national government. However, her return also created a major security challenge. Bhutto was a highly recognizable political figure who needed to appear publicly and interact with large crowds, but she was simultaneously receiving threats from militant organizations.

2.12 Why Benazir Bhutto Was Threatened

Benazir Bhutto faced threats for several overlapping reasons. The most clearly documented threats came from militant and extremist organizations that opposed her political beliefs and viewed her as an enemy of their ideology. Bhutto supported democratic elections and civilian government, opposed extremist violence and supported the Pakistani state's efforts against

militant organizations. She was also viewed by some extremists as being too closely aligned with the United States and Western countries. Her return therefore created the possibility that a major civilian political leader could gain power and influence Pakistan's policies toward militant organizations. The later United Nations Commission of Inquiry specifically examined threats from Al Qaida, Pakistani Taliban groups and other jihadi organizations. The Commission also examined allegations concerning elements within Pakistan's political and security establishment. However, these categories must not be treated as proof that every organization or institution accused by political actors was responsible for her death.

2.13 Al Qaida and the Threat Against Bhutto

Al Qaida represented one of the most serious ideological threats to Bhutto. The organization rejected democratic political systems and regarded governments cooperating with the United States as enemies. Bhutto's political programme was fundamentally incompatible with this ideology. She supported elections and civilian government, publicly opposed extremist violence and intended to participate in Pakistan's democratic process. The possibility that she could become Prime Minister again made her politically significant to militant organizations. The United Nations Commission later examined statements and claims connecting Al Qaida to the assassination, but it emphasized that public claims of responsibility did not by themselves establish the complete criminal chain behind the attack.

2.14 The Pakistani Taliban and Baitullah Mehsud

The Pakistani Taliban movement was also rapidly expanding in 2007. Several militant groups operating in Pakistan's tribal areas became increasingly coordinated and the Tehrik e Taliban Pakistan, commonly known as the TTP, was formally established in December 2007 under Baitullah Mehsud. Baitullah Mehsud subsequently became one of the central figures associated with accusations surrounding Bhutto's assassination. Pakistani authorities accused him and militant networks associated with him of involvement. However, the question of exactly who planned, ordered and carried out the assassination remained controversial and required investigation. The emergence of the TTP is nevertheless important because it demonstrates the extremely dangerous militant environment that existed during Bhutto's final weeks.

2.15 The Karachi Bombing of 18 October 2007

The threat against Bhutto became a physical reality on the very day she returned to Pakistan. On 18 October 2007 two explosions occurred near her procession in Karachi's Karsaz area. The attack killed 139 people and injured several hundred others according to Human Rights Watch. Bhutto survived because she was travelling inside an armoured vehicle. The attack was one of the deadliest political attacks in Pakistan's history and demonstrated that militants were prepared to attack Bhutto even in a massive public gathering. The victims included many PPP supporters and volunteers who had gathered to welcome her. The attack fundamentally changed the security environment surrounding Bhutto and forced the PPP to develop additional protection for its leader.

2.16 The Creation of the Jaan Nisaar Benazir Force

Following the Karachi bombing, the PPP significantly strengthened its own security arrangements around Bhutto. This included the creation and expansion of a volunteer organization known as the Jaan Nisaar Benazir force, usually abbreviated as JNB. The name refers to people who were willing to sacrifice themselves for Benazir. The JNB was not a branch of the Pakistan Army, police or intelligence services. It was a PPP organized volunteer security structure made up largely of party workers and volunteers associated with the party's student and youth organizations. Its purpose was to provide an additional protective layer around Bhutto during political events and public processions.

2.18 The Human Shield Around Bhutto

The JNB's security method relied heavily on the use of a human shield. Volunteers surrounded Bhutto's vehicle and formed a barrier between her and the thousands of people who lined the procession route. This was particularly important if a suicide bomber was able to sneak in amongst the crowd and attempt to attack the vehicle. The human chain was designed to make the approach more difficult, but the system was extremely dangerous for the volunteers and during the Karachi bombing, many of the people killed were JNB volunteers who had been standing around Bhutto's vehicle. The security organization involved ordinary political supporters that were placed deliberately in a position where they could be killed while protecting their leader.

2.19 The Armoured Vehicle

The PPP also used an armoured vehicle to protect Bhutto during her public appearances. A bulletproof truck was prepared for Bhutto's Karachi procession, enabling her to see the supporters while providing protection from gunfire and particular types of attack. The combination of an armoured vehicle, a human shield of volunteers and official police protection represented an extremely extensive security operation. Nevertheless, the Karachi attack demonstrated that even thousands of security personnel and volunteers could not guarantee safety from a determined suicide attacker.

2.20 The Government's Responsibility for Bhutto's Protection

Although the PPP created the JNB, the responsibility for protecting Bhutto ultimately rested with the Pakistani government. This distinction became extremely important after her assassination. The JNB was a party organization and could supplement state protection, but it could not replace the responsibility of the police and other government security institutions. This resulted in two overlapping security structures. Government agencies were responsible for official protection, intelligence and policing, while the PPP organized its own volunteers and security personnel around Bhutto. The existence of two systems created questions concerning coordination, communication and responsibility that became central to the later UN investigation.

2.21 Continued Threats After the Karachi Bombing

The Karachi bombing did not put an end to the threats that existed against Bhutto. In addition to the continued warnings, multiple threats reached her and political associates. The later UN investigation documented several threats during the period between her return and her assassination. On 23 October 2007, just five days after the Karachi bombing, PPP lawyer Farooq Naek received a handwritten letter threatening Bhutto and claiming a connection to suicide bombers and Al Qaida. Naek informed the authorities and requested increased protection. This incident is particularly important because it shows that the threat against Bhutto was known before 27 December. The authorities were not dealing with an entirely unexpected assassination attempt. There was evidence that Bhutto was a high value target.

1.22 Bhutto's Distrust of the Security Establishment

Bhutto did not have complete faith in the official security apparatus. Her distrust was influenced by her political conflict with Musharraf and by concerns that some individuals within the state establishment may be hostile to her political ambitions. Bhutto and people close to her publicly raised allegations that elements of the government or security services could potentially be associated with threats against her. These allegations became more serious after the Karachi bombing. However, the allegations should not be presented as evidence of proof that the Pakistani government ordered her assassination. The later UN Commission examined these concerns and criticized the state's security and investigative failures, but it did not establish that the Pakistani military or government as an institution had ordered Bhutto's murder.

2.23 Nawaz Sharif's Return

Benazir Bhutto was not the only major opposition politician returning to Pakistan during this period. Nawaz Sharif, who had been overthrown by Musharraf in 1999, also returned to Pakistan in November 2007. This meant that two former Prime Ministers and leaders of major political parties were once again operating inside Pakistan at the same time. Bhutto led the PPP and Sharif led the PML N. Both opposed important aspects of Musharraf's political system, although their political programmes and relationships with the military were different. Their simultaneous return increased political competition and made the upcoming general election one of the most important political contests in Pakistan's recent history.

2.24 The Approaching General Election

The general election was scheduled for 8 January 2008. The Election Commission issued the election schedule on 20 November 2007 after the National Assembly had completed its five year constitutional term on 15 November. A caretaker government headed by Muhammad Mian Soomro had been established to oversee the transition towards the elections. Benazir Bhutto's PPP was one of the major parties that would compete, while PML N, PML Q, MQM, ANP and religious political parties were also preparing for the election. The election therefore represented a major opportunity for Pakistan to return to civilian democratic politics after the political crisis

surrounding Musharraf's presidency and the emergency.

2.25 The Security Dilemma of Political Campaigning

Bhutto faced a fundamental contradiction during the election campaign that involved the need for her to hold public rallies in order to compete. She was able to travel through the cities, speak to voters and remain visible, however, each public appearance created an opportunity for an attacker to reach her. To completely isolate Bhutto was almost impossible to enable normal political campaigning, but allowing her to travel openly through large crowds would present a serious security risk. The Karachi attack demonstrated that even a massive security operation could fail. The PPP therefore continued to use the JNB and armoured vehicles while government authorities were expected to provide official protection. This dilemma became increasingly important as Bhutto continued campaigning during December.

2.26 The Final Political Environment

By December 2007, Pakistan was facing several crises simultaneously. Musharraf had only recently ended the state of emergency. The judiciary had suffered disruption. Political opposition was growing. Militant attacks were continuing. The general election was approaching. Benazir Bhutto had already survived one major assassination attempt and continued to receive threats. The PPP had created its own security organization and the state was responsible for official protection. Bhutto's return therefore had not brought stability to Pakistan, but had placed one of the country's most important political leaders into an already unstable political and security environment.

2.27 Liaquat Bagh On 27 December 2007,

Benazir Bhutto travelled to Rawalpindi to address a PPP election rally at Liaquat Bagh. The location was historically significant because Pakistan's first Prime Minister, Liaquat Ali Khan, had been assassinated at the same location in 1951. Bhutto was therefore appearing at a location already associated with political assassination. The rally took place only twelve days after Musharraf had lifted the state of emergency and less than two weeks before the scheduled general election. The political stakes were extremely high because Bhutto was one of the central figures in the election campaign and the PPP was one of the country's largest political parties.

2.28 The Security Plan at Liaquat Bagh

The authorities prepared a formal security plan for Bhutto's appearance and this involved police deployment, security cordons, searching people entering the rally area, personnel positioned around the venue and arrangements for protecting Bhutto's convoy. The plan also involved a protective formation around her vehicle to prevent unauthorized people from approaching her and to protect her while she travelled through the crowd. The later UN Commission found significant weaknesses in both planning and implementation of these arrangements and concluded that the plan concentrated heavily on crowd control and did not sufficiently prioritize Bhutto's personal protection. It also found discrepancies between the security formation outlined by police officials and what actually happened.

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